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Do political and social accountability arrangements increase citizens' legitimacy perceptions? A vignette experiment in the Netherlands

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ABSTRACT
This study investigates the effects of social and political accountability arrangements on citizens' legitimacy perceptions. Accountability arrangements are often suggested to improve the perceived legitimacy of governmental organizations. Based upon a pre-registered vignette experiment with a representative sample of $N = 1574$ citizens from the Netherlands, we show that social accountability (accountability to citizens) increases legitimacy perceptions, but that political accountability (accountability to politicians) does not affect legitimacy perceptions. These patterns are highly similar for both decision winners and losers, with accountability slightly more important for losers. This has important implications for our understanding of the impact of accountability for perceived legitimacy.

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KEYWORDS Accountability; legitimacy; political accountability; social accountability; procedural fairness

Introduction

Public accountability is often seen as a cornerstone of good governance. According to the academic literature, accountability could for instance contribute to democratic control and organizational learning (Schillemans 2011; Willems and Van Dooren 2012). In addition, public accountability can help foster public consent, by strengthening the perceived legitimacy of governmental organizations and increasing citizens' trust in and support for political institutions (Aucoin and Heintzman 2000; Bovens 2010; Greiling 2014). Whereas ill-designed or badly managed accountability arrangements 'could reinforce the idea that the responsiveness of public officials and agencies is something of a charade', meaningful accountability practices can promote the trustworthiness and acceptance of governmental authorities among the general public (Bovens, Schillemans, and 't Hart 2008, 239). However, despite these potential benefits, there has been limited attention for citizens' attitudes towards public accountability in the accountability literature (see, for an exception, Pérez Durán 2016).

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Borrowing insights from procedural fairness theory, this study investigates the consequences of two types of accountability – political and social accountability – for citizens' legitimacy perceptions. To do so, we employ novel survey data from a representative sample of $N = 1574$ citizens from the Netherlands, fielded in February 2022, including a pre-registered vignette experiment especially designed for this research endeavour. Using a fictional scenario of a decision-making procedure on the relocation of fire stations by a Dutch safety region (*veiligheidsregio)*, we manipulate the type of accountability – no accountability, political accountability, and social accountability – and outcome favourability – negative and positive decision outcomes. This allows us to investigate whether the use of both political and social accountability arrangements can enhance legitimacy perceptions (captured as fairness perceptions, decision acceptance and trust) and whether they do so for both decision winners and losers (cf. Esaiasson et al. 2019). Taken together, we seek to answer the following research question: *To what extent do social and political accountability arrangements affect citizens' legitimacy perceptions?*

In doing so, this article contributes to the literature in three ways. First, our *empirical contribution* is that we are among the first to demonstrate the consequences of accountability arrangements for citizens' legitimacy perceptions. As we differentiate between two forms of accountability – political and social accountability arrangements – our research allows us to test whether these social accountability arrangements have a different impact on legitimacy perceptions compared to traditional forms of political accountability, as Bovens (2007, 457) has theorized. We further investigate whether accountability has different consequences depending on outcome favourability. Accountability can be particularly relevant for citizens' legitimacy perceptions under conditions when citizens are confronted with unfavourable policy decisions. Existing research on the so-called winner-loser gap suggests that policy outcomes affects citizens' evaluations of governmental authorities. Losers tend to perceive the policy outcomes and the responsible authorities as less legitimate compared to winners. However, aspects of decision-making procedures, including accountability, have often been put forward as a potential solution for increasing losers' willingness to consider policy outcomes as fair and appropriate, and accordingly to foster legitimacy beliefs (Anderson et al. 2005; Esaiasson, Arnesen, and Werner 2023; Werner and Marien 2022). We therefore expect that public accountability positively affects perceived legitimacy in general and can even compensate negative policy outcomes.

Second, our *theoretical contribution* is that we bridge streams of literature on public accountability, procedural fairness, and citizens' process preferences. Based upon procedural fairness theory, we argue that accountability processes can have an important signalling function that procedures are fair and appropriate thereby increasing the likelihood that citizens accept decisions and trust the decision-makers (see e.g. Lind and Tyler 1988; Tyler 2006; Van den Bos, Wilke, and Lind 1998). As such, we provide a novel perspective to academic debates about the connections between accountability and legitimacy. We also extend the procedural fairness literature by demonstrating how post-decisional accountability processes can be of relevance for perceived legitimacy (cf. De Fine Licht, Agerberg, and Esaiasson 2022).

Finally, our study makes a *societal contribution*. In recent years, various politicians and scholars have proposed social accountability (i.e. direct accountability to citizens and clients) as a supplement or an alternative to political accountability (Mattei, Mitra, and Feiler 2018). In multiple realms of the public sector, governmental organizations

have implemented mechanisms and arrangements to be directly accountable vis-à-vis citizens, clients, and the public at large (Brummel 2021). Although social accountability is often suggested to contribute to the legitimacy of governmental authorities (Hansen, Triantafillou, and Christensen 2022; Klijn and Koppenjan 2014; Sørensen and Torfing 2021), its actual impact on citizens' legitimacy perceptions remains largely undiscovered. Meanwhile, the perceived legitimacy of governmental authorities and their decisions is highly important because it promotes political stability and it facilitates citizens' compliance with public policy measures (see, for example, Grimes 2006). With our experimental study, we aim to investigate whether social accountability arrangements can increase citizens' legitimacy perceptions.

Theoretical framework

Accountability, political and social accountability

As '*the* über-concept of the late 20th and early 21st centuries' (Flinders 2011, 597) in modern governance, accountability has received a lot of scholarly attention. Many different theoretical frameworks and conceptualizations of accountability have emerged in the academic literature (see e.g. Bovens 2007; Day and Klein 1987; Hupe and Hill 2007; Willems and Van Dooren 2012). In this article, we follow Bovens (2007, 2010) influential conceptual contribution to defining accountability that considers accountability as a relational mechanism that connects an account-giver with an accountholder in which the former is answerable to the latter. Accountability can then be defined as 'a relationship between an actor and a forum, in which the actor has an obligation to explain and to justify his or her conduct, the forum can pose questions and pass judgement, and the actor may face consequences' (Bovens 2007, 450).

Public accountability is a broad concept where account-giving can be directed to multiple account-holders (Willems and Van Dooren 2012). From a democratic perspective, two types of accountability are of particular importance for the legitimacy of governmental decisions: *political accountability* and *social accountability*.[1] These two types of accountability reflect two distinct notions of how the democratic accountability of governance can be strengthened (Hansen, Triantafillou, and Christensen 2022; Klijn and Koppenjan 2014; Mattei, Christensen, and Pilaar 2015). Traditionally, the democratic function of accountability is secured by the vertical and hierarchical lines of political accountability (Behn 2001). Political accountability is located within the opposite direction of the so-called 'democratic chain of delegation' (Strøm 2000), whereby each agent should be obliged to give an account to a hierarchical superior. It reflects 'the direct line or chain of accountability [that] links the public servant with the Permanent Head (or CEO), in turn accountable to the minister, to the executive or cabinet, to parliament and hence to the electors' (Sinclair 1995, 225). As such, political accountability is rooted in the notion of the 'primacy of politics', that attributes answerability to civil servants for their deeds and actions towards elected politicians that have ultimate decision-making authority in representative democracy (Klijn and Koppenjan 2014; Klijn and Skelcher 2007).

Social accountability, on the other hand, can be defined as the direct and explicit accountability relationships of public sector organizations vis-à-vis audiences that consist of citizens, clients, or societal actors (Brummel 2021; Sørensen and Torfing 2021). Whereas political accountability is embedded within a system of representative

democracy, social accountability reflects a form of accountability that is consistent with a direct and participatory type of democracy (Hupe and Hill 2007). Given the increasing complexity of the public sector, many have argued that the traditional system with hierarchical and political accountability relations should be supplemented with horizontal and societal modes of accountability (Hansen, Triantafillou, and Christensen 2022; Lægreid and Rykkja 2022). In political and academic discourses, social accountability is often heralded as a democratic innovation by providing citizens and societal actors a greater influence within public sector accountability (Mattei, Mitra, and Feiler 2018). Social accountability does not follow a 'fixed format' but often takes place through (social) media, public reporting, and public panels (Meijer 2007, 168). Social accountability is often voluntary in nature and is associated with informal and reputational consequences (i.e. voice, reputation damage, or 'naming and shaming'), rather than with formal sanctions (Busuioc and Lodge 2016; De Boer 2023). In the absence of formal sanctions, these felt consequences can be highly influential for the individual behaviours of public managers and officials (Overman, Schillemans, and Grimmelikhuijsen 2021). In particular, the use of citizens' charters and client panels is suggested to reflect an important trend towards greater social accountability in public governance (Bovens 2007; Schillemans 2011).

The effects of accountability on citizens' legitimacy perceptions

In the academic literature, there is a widespread idea that accountability is important for strengthening the legitimacy of the public sector (Bovens 2007, 2010; Olsen 2013; Schmidt and Wood 2019). However, so far limited empirical knowledge exists about the actual effects of accountability arrangements on citizens' *legitimacy perceptions* of public institutions and their decisions (cf. Pérez Durán 2016).

Legitimacy has been a contested concept – there is an important distinction between legitimacy as a normative concept and legitimacy as an empirical concept. In disciplines such as political philosophy and law, legitimacy is a normative concept that is associated with moral criteria, such as justice, legal standards, or other 'objective', externally given requirements (Beetham 2013; Buchanan 2002). The social sciences, including political science and public administration, typically adopt an empirical approach to legitimacy. This understanding of legitimacy is also referred as 'subjective' or 'perceived' legitimacy, as it captures how citizens or other actors (e.g. stakeholders) perceive and experience legitimacy in practice from their subjective points of view. Perceived legitimacy reflects the extent to which members of a political community share a belief that existing authorities and their actions are 'appropriate, proper, and just' (Tyler 2006, 375; see also De Fine Licht, Agerberg, and Esaiasson 2022; Werner and Marien 2022).

Normative and subjective notions of legitimacy are however linked, as citizens' evaluations of the legitimacy of political authorities might overlap with normative evaluations of legitimacy that can be found in various philosophical traditions (Buchanan 2002; Tyler and Jost 2007). It is however also possible that citizens consider an institution as legitimate, even if it does not meet normative standards of legitimacy as outlined in political philosophy – or vice versa (Hough et al. 2010). Perceptions of legitimacy are fundamental for democratic societies because they provide the base for citizens to accept and voluntarily comply with decisions of governmental authorities (Grimes 2006; Tyler 2006).

Based upon the accountability literature and procedural fairness theory, multiple arguments can be identified to explain why accountability practices could positively contribute to citizens' legitimacy perceptions. In the accountability literature, accountability is often described as normatively desirable and many authors consider accountability as a 'virtue' of good governance (Bovens 2010; Dubnick 2014; Pollitt and Hupe 2011). An often-made theoretical claim is that accountability could contribute to reassuring and increasing public confidence in government (see also Aucoin and Heintzman 2000; Bovens 2007; Halachmi and Holzer 2010). Accountability is a form of expected and appropriate behaviour (Olsen 2013) and, as Greiling (2014, 624) suggests, it 'is regarded as an instrument which signals competence and organisational trustworthiness and demonstrates how compliance and procedural fairness are met (. . .)'. Particularly, existing research into citizens' accountability preferences shows that citizens in general consider accountability to be important for democracy (Bryson and MacCarthaigh 2022; Pérez Durán 2016).

In addition, the nexus between accountability and legitimacy perceptions is reflected in novel reputational approaches to accountability that consider accountability procedures and practices as communicative strategies of public institutions to achieve legitimate authority across external audiences (Busuioc and Lodge 2016; De Boer 2023). Within this literature, accountability is seen as a means to legitimize organizational conduct and to appear legitimate 'among multiple audiences "that matter"', including informal audiences, such as the public at large (Busuioc and Rimkutė 2020, 1262). Governmental authorities can obtain a positive reputation among the wider public through accountability activities (Christensen and Lodge 2018; Rimkutė and Mazepus 2023; Wood 2015).

The procedural fairness literature provides further ground for the legitimizing effect of accountability mechanisms. Procedural fairness theory argues that citizens not only care about outcomes, but also evaluate their authorities on the basis of the procedures that are associated with these outcomes. The central notion is that citizens will be more likely to accept the outcome of a decision-making process if they consider the procedures as fair and just, for instance if they feel that the process is open and inclusive, and authorities are respectful to citizens (Esaiasson et al. 2019; Lind and Tyler 1988; Tyler 2006). While accountability consists of a justifying dimension (Pérez Durán 2016), procedural fairness literature suggests that elements of explanation and justification can importantly contribute to (perceived) fair procedures and acceptability of one's authority (Tyler 2000). Account-giving can further be interpreted as a sign that decision-making authorities are concerned about the effects of their decisions for the well-being of others (cf. Shapiro, Buttner, and Barry 1994). As accountability scholars focus on retrospective and post-decisional *(ex post facto)* processes of account-holding and account-giving (Bovens 2007), it is particularly relevant that procedural fairness research indicates that not only pre-decision arrangements, but also post-decision arrangements (i.e. announcements, explanations and post-decision voice), can contribute to perceived legitimacy (see e.g. De Fine Licht, Agerberg, and Esaiasson 2022; Lind, Kanfer, and Earley 1990).

Based upon these multiple streams of literature, we thus expect that accountability will increase the likelihood that citizens consider procedures as fair and support a decision and that these effects will hold for both political and social accountability. The first hypothesis therefore reads as:

Hypothesis 1: Decision-making procedures with explicit account giving to citizens (H1.1) or to politicians (H1.2) lead to higher legitimacy perceptions compared to decision-making procedures where account-giving does not take place.

A subsequent question is whether the type of – political and social – accountability generates different effects for citizens' decision acceptance and trust. There is no consensus within the literature on which type of accountability has a larger impact for legitimacy perceptions. On the one hand, the accountability literature suggests that in particular social accountability can increase fairness perceptions of citizens. Bovens (2007, 457) for instance argues that 'processes of accountability [...] in which citizens and interest groups can pose questions and offer their opinion' can contribute to the confidence of citizens in governmental organizations (see also Halachmi and Holzer 2010; Moore 2014). According to Hansen, Triantafillou, and Christensen (2022), social accountability can be particularly relevant for governance legitimacy, because it makes governmental authorities accountable and responsive to citizens that are directly affected by their decisions and policies.

Similarly, theories of participatory democracy often assume that citizens prefer a greater citizen involvement in public and political affairs (see e.g. Barber 1984; Fung and Wright 2001; Norris 1999). Across various Western democracies, public opinion surveys have suggested that citizens tend to prefer greater opportunities for citizen involvement in public sector decision-making (see e.g. Bowler, Donovan, and Karp 2007; DaltonBurklin, and Drummond 2001). Participatory innovations are often found to stimulate citizens' positive procedure evaluations (Esaiasson, Gilljam, and Persson 2012; Herian et al. 2012; Morrell 1999). Novel research has indicated that citizen involvement in public decision-making can also contribute to fairness perceptions among wider groups of citizens, also including those that do not participate and/or are not willing to participate (Aizenberg, Werner, and van Geldere 2023; Jacobs and Kaufmann 2021; Werner and Marien 2022).

This also corresponds to the procedural fairness literature, which considers experienced voice opportunities as a core feature of a fair process (Hirschman 1970). According to procedural fairness theory, voice enhances a sense of control during the decision-making process, leading to higher fairness perceptions and decision acceptability (Thibaut and Walker 1975). Moreover, people also care about voice opportunities for relational and symbolic rather than instrumental reasons (Lind and Tyler 1988).

Still, it is important to note that there is also existing work that critically questions whether social accountability can contribute to citizens' legitimacy perceptions, compared to political accountability. For example, Grimes (2006) found that unbiased and transparent decision-making procedures contribute to citizens' legitimacy perceptions, but citizen influence during a process is less important for their legitimacy beliefs (cf. Arnesen 2017; De Fine Licht 2014). Similarly, the theory on stealth democracy argues that citizens want a decision system that is built on democratic ideals, but do not want or need to take part in such a system – except in unusual circumstances (Hibbing and Theiss-Morse 2001). In line with this, the public administration literature reports low levels of citizens' interest and willingness to participate in accountability activities and practices (see e.g. Curtin and Meijer 2006; Meijer 2007).

Building on the dominant insights from accountability studies, participation literature and procedural fairness theory, we predict a stronger effect for social accountability compared to political accountability. Our second hypothesis is outlined as:

Hypothesis 2: Decision-making procedures with explicit account giving to citizens lead to higher legitimacy perceptions compared to decision-making procedures with explicit account giving to politicians.

Furthermore, the effects of accountability on legitimacy perceptions are particularly important when a political decision has negative consequences for citizens. Outcome favourability – i.e. whether someone is a so-called 'decision winner' or 'decision loser' – is found to largely shape citizens' process evaluations and their willingness to accept decisions (Arnesen 2017; Esaiasson et al. 2019). Empirical research has documented that losing reduces the perceived legitimacy of decisions and decision-making processes – and this is not only relevant in the context of elections and referenda, but also applies to policy conflicts (De Fine Licht, Agerberg, and Esaiasson 2022; Esaiasson, Arnesen, and Werner 2023).

There are several explanations for this winner-loser gap (see Anderson et al. 2005, 23–29 for an elaborative discussion). As winners gain more utilities from a decision-making process than losers, they are more inclined to consider the process as legitimate. The effects of winning and losing in decision-making can further reflect a general psychological mechanism, whereby a victory creates positive emotions, such as happiness, while losing leads to negative emotional responses, such as anger and disillusion. In addition, decision losers might be subject to cognitive dissonance, which fosters them to change their attitudes towards the decision-making process through the lenses of their loser status. As negative experiences have a stronger effects on individuals than positive ones (Baumeister et al. 2001), legitimacy perceptions of decision losers can even decline more strongly than those of decision winners increase. Yet, the willingness of citizens on the losing side to accept political decisions – losers' consent – is essential for democratic legitimacy (Anderson et al. 2005). An important notion in the procedural fairness literature is that fair and appropriate procedural arrangements in decision-making could enhance citizens' willingness to accept a decision, even if they confronted with an unfavourable decision outcome (Tyler 2006). Accordingly, procedural arrangements, such as accountability practices, can help generate losers' consent by compensating for the negative effects of an unfavourable decision outcome (see also König et al. 2022).

It is important to note that it can be unclear who can be classified as a decision winner or loser in governmental decision-making, because citizens have multiple identities and interests in their relationships towards governmental authorities (Aberbach and Christensen 2005). Additionally, citizens are not only concerned about the consequences of governmental decisions for their own individual self-interest, but also care about the collective effects of these decisions for wider communities (Kim 2014; Leung, Tong, and Lind 2007). Given the importance of outcome favourability for citizens' fairness perceptions, we however argue that the potential benefits of accountability processes should be studied by focussing specifically on decision losers, because, compared to winners, their legitimacy perceptions are most likely to be negatively affected. At the same time, their acceptance of unfavourable

decisions (i.e. their losers' consent) is most critical to democratic legitimacy (Brummel 2020; Werner and Marien 2022).

In sum, while we are interested in the legitimizing effects of accountability in general, we also believe a more important test is assessing losers' reactions to accountability procedures. In line with the losers' consent literature, we expect that accountability is more important for decision losers than for decision winners. Specifically, we predict that the status of decision loser moderates the relationship between accountability and perceived legitimacy. This leads to the final hypothesis of the study:

Hypothesis 3: Among decision losers, decision-making procedures with explicit account giving to citizens (H3.1) or to politicians (H3.2) lead to higher legitimacy perceptions compared to decision-making procedures where account-giving does not take place.

Data and methods

To test above hypotheses, this study employs a vignette experiment in order to understand the effects of different types of accountability on citizens' legitimacy perceptions. The vignette experiment was embedded in an online survey and was conducted in the Netherlands among a representative sample of N = 1574 Dutch citizens.[2] Data was collected within the Dutch LISS Panel (Longitudinal Internet Studies for the Social Sciences) in the period between 7 February 2022, and 29 March 2022. The LISS Panel consists of 5,000 households, comprising approximately 7,500 individuals, and is based on a true probability sample of Dutch households drawn from the official population register by Statistics Netherlands (CBS). Households that could not otherwise participate are provided with a computer and Internet connection. More detailed information about the survey and sampling procedures are available on the LISS website (http://www.lissdata.nl/).

Information about the composition and characteristics of the sample can be found in Appendix I. There are no significant differences between experimental groups with regards to gender, age, education, and left-right self-placement (Gender: χ^2 (5, N = 1754) = 7.108, $p = 0.213$; Age: F(5, 1748) = 0.831, $p = 0.527$; Education: χ^2 (10, N = 1748) = 9.050, $p = 0.527$; Left-right self-placement: F(5, 1498) = 0.486, $p = 0.787$).

Prior to the data collection, the research design was preregistered via the Open Science Framework (OSF) and information about the preregistration can be found on https://osf.io/njdp6/?view_only=98fbffab84d842128e662bb123a1a07d. Ethical approval was obtained from our local Faculty's Ethical Review Committee (no. 23–014). Our experimental analyses did not deviate from the analytical steps outlined in our pre-registration, although some analyses are presented in the Supplementary Materials. The time of data collection has however been extended. Because of a technical error, a small number of survey items was not visible for some respondents during the first two weeks of data collection. We decided to put the entire version of the questionnaire online in mid-February and send the respondents who had already finished the questionnaire a request to complete these additional questions. As a consequence, we extended the period of data collection until the end of

March 2022. The survey items, that were subject to a technical error, were not part of the experimental analyses, and, as such, did not influence our study's results.

Experimental design

For our study we designed a 2 × 3between-subjects randomized survey experiment in which each respondent is confronted with only one treatment or vignette. A vignette is a 'short, carefully constructed description of a person, object, or situation, representing a systematic combination of characteristics' (Atzmüller and Steiner 2010, 128). The use of experimental research has as one of its major advantages that it provides a more accurate picture of causal effects by isolating the effects of other confounding factors and, as such, increasing internal validity. In particular, vignette experiments are well suited to study citizens' responses to specific situations or circumstances, as they embed questions in a concrete, realistic context and are therefore less abstract and more realistic than conventional survey designs (Steiner, Atzmüller, and Su 2016, 53).

The vignette discussed a decision made by a Dutch safety region (or so-called *veiligheidsregio)* with regards to a local fire station. A safety region is a public body that operate in the domains of security and emergency policies in a specified regional area that covers the full territories of multiple municipalities. Safety regions are a form of regional governance based on the cooperation between local authorities (Klok et al. 2018) and the Netherlands is currently divided in 25 safety regions. Since their establishment in 2010, safety regions are responsible for multiple emergency and security issues, including the fire services, according to the Safety Regions Act. Because of the limited direct influence and control of elected politicians over safety regions, there have been concerns about the democratic accountability of safety regions (see e.g. Muller et al. 2020).

The rationale for focusing on fire service policies was to provide participants with a realistic decision that is generally easy to understand and that could be relevant for every Dutch citizen. The vignette was formulated in such a way that it was understandable for readers with B1-level Dutch. The scenario could further generate clear positive or negative consequences for participants. We select a safety region as a decision-making body in our experiment because of its executive and non-partisan nature and because citizens do not often have direct contact with safety regions. Participants' responses are therefore less likely to be influenced by previous experiences, personal prejudices and/or biases. Because of the restricted accountability of safety regions, results are further unlikely to be affected by participants' expectations about the formal and actual accountability of safety regions. Additionally, safety regions are not an unknown and invisible form of governance in the Netherlands. Between 1 February 2020, and 1 February 2022, a total of 1,486 newspaper articles, mentioning 'safety region', has been published in one of the five largest national newspapers in the Netherlands.[3] As most Dutch citizens will be informed about the existence of safety regions, this contributes to the ecological validity of our experiment.

In the experimental setup, participants read a vignette and were either informed that the safety region closes a fire station in their neighbourhood (a *negative decision outcome)* or opens a new fire station in the participant's neighbourhood (a *positive decision outcome)*. As a consequence of the decision, the arrival time of the fire brigade would either increase or decrease with 15 minutes for the specific case of the participant. After reading about the decision outcome,

participants were randomly assigned to one of the three accountability treatments. For some of the participants, there was no further information provided about the accountability processes with regards to the safety region's decision (*no accountability* treatment). The *no accountability* condition forms the baseline category in this study.[4] Under the *political accountability* treatment, participants were informed that the safety region gave an account about its decision plans to close/open a fire station vis-à-vis local politicians from municipalities within the specific region. If participants were assigned to the *social accountability* treatment, they were informed that the safety region involved citizens in the accountability processes about its fire service policies. For both accountability treatments, the accountability process was described in such a way that it reflects all three dimensions or phases of Bovens' (2007) conceptualization of accountability by including elements of information provision, debate and the possibilities of judgement and consequences. To reduce potential risks of experimenter demand effects, we did not refer to 'accountability' in the vignette. Participants were neither informed about the aim and the nature of the vignette experiment. An English translation of the vignette is presented in Textbox 1 (see Appendix II for the version in Dutch).

Textbox 1. Full text of vignette (translated to English).

Imagine the following situation happening in your area of residence

The Netherlands is divided into 25 safety regions. Municipalities work together in a safety region. They do this to ensure the security of the residents. For example, the safety region decides on the fire service.

[Negative/positive decision treatment] The safety region where you live has a plan for the fire service. The fire service must be able to do its work better and smarter. In the policy plan, the fire station in your neighbourhood closes/a new fire station opens in your neighbourhood. If there is an accident or fire in your neighbourhood, the fire brigade is 15 minutes longer/shorter on its way.

[No accountability treatment] The safety region can take these kinds of decisions autonomously.

[Political/Social accountability treatment] The safety region can take these kinds of decisions autonomously. To make a good decision, the safety region does discuss this plan with politicians/citizens from the municipality. The safety region explains the plan during meetings with politicians/citizens. During these meetings politicians/citizens can ask questions about the plan and about the implementation of the plan. They can also give their own ideas. The safety region takes the ideas of politicians/citizens very seriously when implementing the plan for the fire service.

Taken together, our design manipulates two dimensions: outcome favourability and the degree/type of accountability. Participants were informed about a decision with either (1) positive or (2) negative outcomes. The experimental design had three accountability treatments: (1) a treatment without account-giving, (2) a treatment with account-giving directed to politicians or (3) a treatment with account-giving directed to citizens. This results in six different experimental conditions, also reflected in Table 1.

Table 1. Overview of six different vignette scenarios.

	Positive outcome	Negative outcome
None accountability	(1) No accountability x Positive outcome	(2) No accountability x Negative outcome
Accountability to politicians	(3) Political accountability x Positive outcome	(4) Political accountability x Negative outcome
Accountability to citizens	(5) Social accountability x Positive outcome	(6) Social accountability x Negative outcome

Outcome variables

Our core variable of interest is (institutional) legitimacy, which is a concept that is hard to measure directly (Thomas 2014). Hence, we focus specifically on the legitimacy of authorities as perceived by citizens, also referred to as subjective or perceived legitimacy (Hibbing and Theiss-Morse 2001; Tyler 1988). In line with previous research on procedural fairness, we capture this using fairness perceptions of the decision-making arrangement (cf. Werner and Marien 2022). Past research has repeatedly shown that the fairness of procedures is closely linked to other core facets of legitimacy, such as trust in authorities and decision acceptance (De Fine Licht et al. 2014, 2022; Esaiasson et al. 2019; Grimes 2006). To increase robustness, we also employ two additional operationalizations of our dependent variable, that is decision acceptance (also referred to as consent) and trust in the decision-making authority. We thus operationalize citizens' legitimacy perceptions as (1) fairness perceptions, (2) decision acceptance and (3) trust.[5] In the results section, we focus on fairness perceptions, but we report our findings for decision acceptance and trust in Appendices IV-V.

In the vignette experiment, *fairness perceptions* were measured by a single survey item: 'The decision to close/open the fire station has been made fairly'. To measure *decision acceptance*, respondents were asked to respond to the following item: 'I accept the decision to close/open the fire station'. Both items were measured on a seven-point Likert scale, with answer options varying from 'Fully disagree' (1) to 'Fully agree' (7). These items are highly comparable to often-used measures in procedural fairness research (see also Esaiasson et al. 2019). The measurement of *trust in decision-makers* was based upon a shortened version of Grimmelikhuijsen and Knies's (2017) three-dimensional scale for trust in public organizations (see Grimmelikhuijsen, Bouwman, and De Vries 2020). The shortened scale consists of the following three items: 'the safety region is fair to citizens', 'the interests of citizens are paramount to the safety region', and 'the safety region carries out its task very well' (Cronbach's $\alpha = 0.902$). Measurement was on a seven-point Likert scale with answer options ranging from 'Fully disagree' (1) to 'Fully agree' (7). Please note that for the regression analyses, we have recoded our outcome variables into an 0–1 format.

Analytical approach

To test our first hypothesis, we take no accountability as a reference category and code respondents as having received a vignette on a procedure with either social accountability (SocialAccount = 1) or political accountability (PoliticalAccount = 1). Moreover, we control for outcome favourability, where respondents who were told in the vignette that a fire station in their neighbourhood was closing were coded as losers (Loser = 1) while those who were told that a fire station was opened even closer to them are coded as a winner (Loser = 0).

We will use the following equation to specify Ordinary Least Squares (OLS) regression models for the first hypothesis[6]:

$$L = \beta_0 + \beta_1\, SocialAccount + \beta_2\, PoliticalAccount + \beta_3\, Loser + e$$

To test our second hypothesis, we will directly compare political and social accountability. Hence, we code our accountability treatment variable in a binary variable thereby leaving out the no accountability condition. Seeing that we expect that the

effect of social accountability trumps that of political accountability, we take political accountability as a reference category (SocialVsPolitical = 0).

$$L = \beta_0 + \beta_1\, SocialVsPolitical + \beta_2\, Loser + e$$

To test our third hypothesis, which focusses specifically on the effects of accountability for so-called losers (those who were told in the vignette that a fire station in their neighbourhood was closing), we will use the following equation to specify OLS regression models for the third hypothesis:

$$L = \beta_0 + \beta_1\, SocialAccount + \beta_2\, PoliticalAccount + \beta_3\, Loser + \beta_4\, SocialAccount * Loser + \beta_5\, PoliticalAccount * Loser + e$$

Additionally, we test for various heterogeneous treatment effects (HTE). This part of the analysis is exploratory, and hence we did not draw hypotheses about these effects. Each heterogeneous treatment effect is tested by interacting them with our accountability (SocialAccount & PoliticalAccount) and/or our decision outcome (Loser) variable. We test for HTE based upon respondents' (1) pre-treatment level of political trust, (2) satisfaction with democracy, (3) support for populist parties, (4) perceived importance of accountability for democracy, (5) perceived insecurity and (6) educational attainment. Appendix VI (Tables A4 – A9) presents and discusses the findings from these exploratory analyses.

Manipulation check, speeder checks, and false discovery rate

At the end of our experiment, we included a factual manipulation check for participants that were subject to one of the two accountability treatments (cf. J. V. Kane and Barabas 2019). For the political accountability treatment, the following survey item was included: 'The safety region discusses its plan for the fire service with politicians'. More than half of the participants in the political accountability treatment agreed with the statement ($N = 275$, 55.5%), while $N = 134$ participants (27.6%) neither disagreed or agreed with the survey item and $N = 47$ participants (9.7%) indicated that they could not provide an answer. Only a small portion of participants ($N = 35$, 7.2%) disagreed with the statement that safety region discusses its plan for the fire service with politicians. In a similar fashion, for the social accountability treatment, participants were asked whether they agreed or disagreed with the following statement: 'The safety region discusses its plan for the fire service with citizens'. Again, a majority of the participants ($N = 275$, 58%) agreed with the statement, while $N = 121$ (25.5%) were neutral and $N = 44$ (9.3%) did not know which one of the options they should choose. Only $N = 34$ participants (7.2%) did not agree with the statement that the safety region discusses its plan for the fire service with citizens.

Taken together, more than half of the participants has responded correctly to the manipulation check, while only a few respondents failed the manipulation check by indicating the wrong answer ('Disagree'). For both the political accountability and the social accountability treatment, the distribution of responses is highly comparable (χ^2 (3, $N = 960$) = 0.672, $p = 0.880$). Remarkably, a considerable number of participants responded with 'Neutral' or 'Don't know' to the manipulation check. In Appendix VII, we zoom in on respondents' answers to the manipulation check. Logistic regression analyses show that

higher educated respondents were significantly more likely to respond correctly to the manipulation check. Noteworthy, for both accountability treatments, fairness perceptions significantly differ based on participants' responses to the manipulation check. Since excluding participants that failed to pass a manipulation check can however generate biases in estimation (Aronow, Baron, and Pinson 2019), we decide to use our full sample in the experimental analyses, but we report the results of our analyses without participants who failed the manipulation check in Appendix VII.

In addition, we also report Complier Average Causal Effect (CACE) estimates (i.e. 2SLS estimates) for our social accountability and political accountability treatments in Appendix VII. Here, treatment assignment serves as an instrument for compliance, which is assessed using a post-treatment measure of attentiveness (i.e. our FMC) (Kane, Velez, and Barabas 2023). The CACE results are in line with our main results.

Furthermore, we re-run our main experimental analyses excluding respondents that were classified as overly fast responders or so-called speeders (see Appendix VIII). In line with Greszki, Meyer, and Schoen (2015), we excluded participants that responded 40% faster to our questionnaire than the median time. For a more inclusive estimate of potential speeders, we further run our experimental analyses excluding participants with a 30% faster response time. These analyses did not yield a different interpretation of our experimental results.

Finally, our experiment might face multiple comparisons problems. We therefore report both unadjusted p-values and adjusted p-values using the Bonferroni correction method, as well as the Benjamini – Hochberg procedure to control for the false discovery rate (Benjamini and Hochberg 1995). We present the unadjusted and adjusted p-values in Appendix X.

Results

To investigate the effect of outcome favourability and type of accountability for fairness perceptions, we first present the descriptive results. Figure 1 shows the mean scores (with a 95% confidence interval) within all six experimental conditions for our outcome variable. We highlight two observations. First, in line with previous research, a clear pattern from the data emerges showing that decision winners are consistently more likely than decision losers to consider the decision procedure as fair (see also Esaiasson et al. 2019; Werner and Marien 2022). On average, decision winners score the fairness of a procedure with $M = 5.30$ (SD = 1.37), while decision losers give it $M = 3.74$ (SD = 1.72) on a seven-point scale (irrespective of the presence of any account-giving). Second, the different types of accountability seem to lead to varying levels of fairness perceptions. That is, among losers, social accountability results in the highest level of perceived fairness ($M = 4.10$, SD = 1.67), while no accountability results in the lowest ($M = 3.40$, SD = 1.75). Political accountability seems to increase fairness perceptions only marginally among losers ($M = 3.71$, SD = 1.69) as compared to no accountability. For winners, it appears that social accountability results in the highest fairness perceptions ($M = 5.51$, SD = 1.12), compared to both political accountability and no accountability, while political accountability does not seem to boost perceived fairness at all ($M = 5.13$, SD = 1.54), as compared to no accountability ($M = 5.25$, SD = 1.38). In other words, account-giving indeed seems to result in higher fairness perceptions, in particular for so-called losers. For winners, this pattern is much less clear.

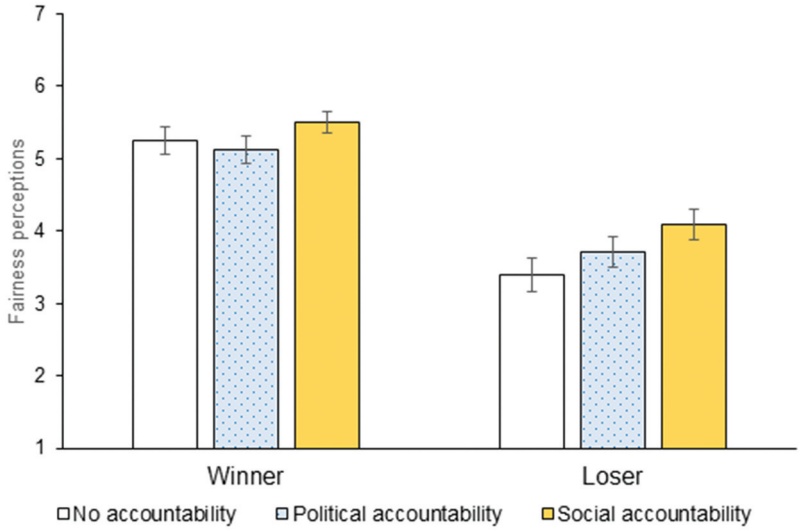

Figure 1. Fairness perceptions on a 1–7 scale: mean scores (with 95% CI).

Moving to our hypotheses, we first empirically test whether account-giving to citizens or to politicians indeed leads to higher fairness perceptions compared to decision-making procedures where account-giving does not take place, as predicted by Hypothesis 1. In Table 2, Model 1 presents the results of an OLS regression model including the effects of a negative decision outcome (compared to a positive decision outcome) and the effects of both political and social accountability (compared to no accountability).[7] The empirical findings do not provide support for Hypothesis 1.1., as political accountability does not increase citizens' fairness perceptions. In other words, political accountability does not have a significant effect on citizens' fairness perceptions, as compared to no accountability (b = 0.017, SE = 0.017, $p = 0.323$). However, the

Table 2. Accountability and perceived fairness: The effects of social and political accountability on citizens' fairness perceptions.

Effect	Model 1 Coeff. (SE)	Model 2 Coeff. (SE)	Model 3 Coeff. (SE)
Constant	0.682*** (0.014)	0.688*** (0.014)	0.708*** (0.018)
Decision outcome (ref = Winner)			
Loser	−0.259*** (0.014)	−0.236*** (0.016)	−0.309*** (0.025)
Type of accountability (ref = No acc.)			
Political accountability	0.017 (0.017)		−0.020 (0.024)
Social accountability	0.082*** (0.017)		0.044[a] (0.024)
Type of accountability (ref = Pol acc.)			
Social accountability		0.065*** (0.016)	
Interaction effects			
Loser x Political acc.			0.072* (0.034)
Loser x Social acc.			0.073* (0.034)
F	126.963***	111.146***	77.597***
R^2	0.213	0.187	0.215
N of cases	1399	960	1399

Note: all items have been (re)coded to range between 0 and 1. The values report unstandardized coefficients (B) from ordinary least squares regression. a$p < 0.1$, *$p < 0.05$, **$p < 0.01$, ***$p < 0.001$.

results provide greater support for Hypothesis 1.2., as social accountability has a significant and positive effect on citizens' fairness perceptions (b = 0.082, SE = 0.017, $p < 0.001$). This means that being told that the safety region explains its plans to citizens, rather than simply taking the decision autonomously without accountability, results in an 8.2% point increase in the perceived fairness of the procedure.

Next, we investigate whether there are substantive differences between the different forms of accountability in their potential to generate perceived fairness, as predicted by Hypothesis 2. Model 2 in Table 2 shows the effects of social accountability on citizens' fairness perceptions, but with political accountability as a reference category. Compared to political accountability, social accountability does significantly increase citizens' fairness perceptions (b = 0.065, SE = 0.016, $p < 0.001$). In other words, social accountability procedures resulted in an increase of fairness perceptions of 6.5% points compared to political accountability procedures. Based upon these findings, Hypothesis 2 can thus be corroborated.

Last, we study whether accountability generates different effects for decision winners and losers, as predicted by Hypothesis 3. Model 3 explicitly tests this hypothesis by including interaction effects between outcome favourability and both political and social accountability. The results provide initial support for Hypothesis 3.1, meaning that the effects of political accountability on citizens' fairness perceptions are conditional upon outcome favourability (b = 0.072, SE = 0.034, $p = 0.034$). Also, for social accountability (Hypothesis 3.2), there is a significant and positive interaction effect with outcome favourability (b = 0.073, SE = 0.034, $p = 0.031$). For both interaction effects, please do however note that the adjusted p-values after the Bonferroni correction and the Benjamini – Hochberg FDR correction are not significant at $\alpha = 0.05$. Despite of the initial support for Hypothesis 3, these corrections suggest that decision winners and losers do not respond very differently to political and social accountability arrangements.

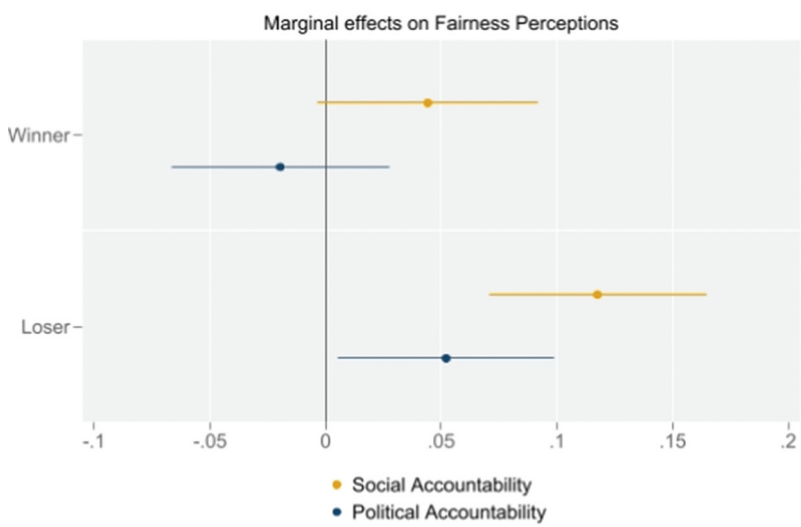

Figure 2. Marginal effects of political and social accountability on winners' and losers' fairness perceptions.

To better grasp these interaction effects, Figure 2 shows the marginal effects of political and social accountability on fairness perceptions for both winners and losers. Social accountability increases the fairness perceptions of losers with 11.75% points, while barely changing the fairness perceptions of winners (marginal effect is 4% points, significant only at $p < 0.1$). Political accountability also significantly increases the fairness perceptions of losers, albeit to a lesser degree (a 5% point increase) while the fairness perceptions of winners do not change with political accountability, compared to no accountability. Although we only report slight differences between decision winners and losers in their responses to accountability arrangements, our findings confirm that decision losers consider decisions as more fair when there is political or social accountability, in contrast to situations where accountability is absent.

Appendices IV-V show the experimental findings for decision acceptance and trust. We observe the same patterns, but with subtle differences. Again, Hypothesis 1.1 is not supported: political accountability does not increase citizens' decision acceptance and trust. Instead, political accountability is associated with a decrease in citizens' levels of decision acceptance. In line with Hypothesis 1.2, a positive relationship between social accountability and citizens' trust in decision-makers is confirmed. Social accountability does however not lead to higher levels of decision acceptance, although the effect was in the expected direction. The findings provide additional support for Hypothesis 2, as both citizens' decision acceptance and trust are significantly higher for social accountability, as compared to political accountability. Support for Hypothesis 3 is mixed. Hypothesis 3.1 is not corroborated: although political accountability does significantly increase decision losers' fairness perceptions, this does not lead to higher levels of decision acceptance and trust (see also Figures A2 and A4). With regards to Hypothesis 3.2, we see a positive marginal effect of social accountability on both decision acceptance and trust. These effects are however somewhat smaller than for fairness perceptions. All in all, Appendices IV-V reflect a pattern in which social accountability is associated with an increase in legitimacy perceptions, while political accountability does not lead to higher legitimacy perceptions.

Conclusion and discussion

Various scholars have suggested that accountability can restore citizens' trust and confidence in public institutions. Our study provides novel insights into the links between accountability and (perceived) legitimacy by testing to what extent political and social accountability arrangements increase citizens' legitimacy perceptions. By conducting a vignette experiment among citizens in the Netherlands, we investigated how both political and social accountability affect perceived legitimacy if citizens were confronted with either a positive or negative decision.

Our findings suggest that accountability has an effect on citizens' legitimacy perceptions, but not all forms of accountability are equally influential. Social accountability contributes positively to citizens' legitimacy perceptions, but political accountability does not. Interestingly, these patterns are highly similar for both decision winners and losers, whereby accountability is only slightly more important for losers than for winners.

Our main contribution is that we provide first empirical support for Bovens' (2007, 457) theoretical assumption that social accountability can contribute to citizens' perceived legitimacy of governmental authorities. Our findings further

extend insights from both the literature on procedural fairness and theories on participatory democracy suggesting that citizens care about voice opportunities for them and their fellow citizens in decision-making procedures. We show that these findings do not only hold for citizen participation in pre-decisional consultations (see e.g. Jacobs and Kaufmann 2021; Werner and Marien 2022), but also for citizen involvement in post-decisional accountability. Yet, not only procedures, but outcomes also matter. This study supports Esaiasson et al'.s (2019) findings that procedural means can have a moderate impact on decision acceptance but that outcome favourability further influences the likelihood that citizens accept decisions. Related to this, it is interesting to mention that our experiment shows that social accountability boosts fairness perceptions, but does not significantly increase decision acceptance.

The null – and sometimes even negative – findings on the associations between political accountability and citizens' legitimacy perceptions are remarkable and in contrast to our hypotheses. These effects should be considered in the light of relatively low levels of political trust in the Netherlands at the time of data collection in February 2022, due to the aftermath of the coronavirus crisis, a lengthy cabinet formation and a series of political incidents and scandals (see also De Blok and Brummel 2022). Generally, citizens' trust in politicians is lower than trust in professional administrators (Van de Walle 2004; Yang and Holzer 2006). As a consequence of growing antipolitical attitudes within democratic societies, citizens might prefer alternative forms of democratic representation and accountability instead of traditional modes of political accountability (Wood 2022). Meanwhile, citizens might perceive accountability processes between politics and administration of limited relevance for their own lives (see Mizrahi and Minchuk 2020), thereby providing an alternative explanation for the relatively small impact of political accountability on perceived legitimacy.

Despite these contributions, our study also comes with some caveats. In the first place, the study raises questions about the generalizability of its findings because our experimental scenario focusses on one single policy decision in a specific country. That said, as Van Ryzin (2015, 431–432) shows, citizens' attitudes towards the fire services are strongly correlated with their attitudes towards a wide array of other public services (i.e. education, policing, and garbage collection), suggesting that our findings might be transferable to these and related policy fields. Nonetheless, the effects of accountability arrangements can be dependent on the type and complexity of a policy issue. For example, Bertsou (2022) finds that citizens are more likely to accept technocratic decision-making processes with low levels of political accountability when the issue at hand is technical in nature, compared to an issue that is highly politicized and/or rooted in cultural and moral conflicts.

Additionally, the effects of different types of accountability on citizens' legitimacy perceptions can be conditional on country context. Whereas our study finds that social accountability increase citizens' legitimacy perceptions in a well-established democracy, such as the Netherlands, existing research shows that aspects of citizen participation and consultation are less relevant to citizens' conceptions of legitimacy in new and transitional democracies (Bertsou and Caramani 2022; Mazepus 2017). For a more fine-grained understanding of the relationship between accountability arrangements and legitimacy perceptions, replication studies are needed in different country settings and with different examples of policy decisions.

Furthermore, this study has a specific focus on two types of accountability: political and social accountability. Public accountability however comes in many different guises, and replications can uncover how different types of accountability, including professional, judicial and bureaucratic accountabilities (Bovens 2007; Willems and Van Dooren 2012), relate to the legitimacy perceptions of citizens. While our initial focus centred on citizens' perceived legitimacy of governmental decisions, further experimentation can include a different subset of potential outcomes of accountability processes, such as citizens' perceptions of organizational performance and/or bureaucratic reputation (cf. Busuioc and Lodge 2016).

Given the hypothetical scenario of our experiment, an important question reflects whether our experiment findings can hold in real-life situations. Although our experimental design reflects a description of a fictional but realistic decision-making procedure, the way in which we presented the accountability treatments can be consequential for our experimental results. External validity is often a complex issue in experimental research. Compared to our simplified accountability scenarios, real-life accountability activities can consist of different processes and mechanisms within a wider context of multiple accountabilities (Bovens, Schillemans, and 't Hart 2008) that might impact how citizens evaluate accountability practices and assess the legitimacy of governmental conduct. In reality, there are multiple factors that can intersect with the relationship between accountability arrangements and legitimacy perceptions. For example, the politicization of accountability, often associated with blame-games, can have important consequences for how citizens perceive accountability processes (Bryson and MacCarthaigh 2022; Flinders 2011). As citizens' understandings of procedures are largely shaped by informational cues, for instance via media (cf. De Fine Licht 2014), media coverage could further moderate the effects of actual accountability procedures on legitimacy perceptions. Although follow-up experimental research might be well-suited to address some of these factors, the accountability literature would particularly benefit from observational research designs, including qualitative ones, that focus on whether and how actual accountability practices relate to citizens' attitudes towards governmental authorities.

Under the assumption that our experimental findings hold in real-world research settings, they have practical implications for governmental organizations. Political accountability is a core principle of representative democracy, but our study suggests that it is not a guarantee for securing citizens' support for governmental organizations and their decisions. Rather, citizens are more likely to accept decisions and decision-making procedures when they are informed about the involvement of their fellow citizens (instead of politicians) in accountability processes. This can be considered as a potential benefit of social accountability arrangements for fostering democratic legitimacy. However, in practice, social accountability is associated with several challenges that might hinder the legitimizing impact of social accountability arrangements. Governmental organizations often experience difficulties in involving citizens and stakeholders in accountability processes (see e.g. Meijer 2007; Papadopoulos 2010). Additionally, social accountability can only increase legitimacy perceptions when the public at large is informed about the existence of social accountability arrangements (cf. Knobloch, Barthel, and Gastil 2020). In other words, the actual involvement of citizens in accountability practices can be beneficial for governmental organizations but it requires that governmental organizations are able to involve citizens in accountability

processes and that these accountability processes are communicated to the wider public.

Finally, as social accountability arrangements can help to legitimize decisions, they can become of strategic and instrumental concern for governmental organizations. When account-giving becomes a strategic resource, it provides challenges to democratic governance (De Boer 2023, 1147). Various studies have documented a strategic aspect in accountability, whereby public authorities proactively engage in relatively low-cost practices of accountability in order to *appear* accountable and legitimate, and as such, aim to cultivate a positive reputation and resist more demanding forms of accountability (Bertelli and Busuioc 2021; Busuioc and Lodge 2016; Karsten 2015). While social accountability arrangements might be useful for strengthening governmental legitimacy, we should carefully consider the motivations of governmental organizations to engage in these types of accountability practices.

Notes

1. Our theoretical argument is most relevant for accountability for decisions, as we are particularly interested in the effects of accountability for the perceived legitimacy of governmental decision-making. Governmental organizations can further render account for a range of different aspects of their organizational conduct, including their finances, procedures, and/or performance (Behn 2001; Bovens 2007).
2. We used G*Power 3.1.9.2. to calculate the minimum sample size to detect our main effects (see Faul et al. 2007). With an effect size of Cohen's f = 0.10, power = 0.90, and alpha = 0.05, a minimal sample size of $n = 1269$ was needed to detect a relatively small main effect with relatively high power.
3. Source: NexisUni. Our search includes newspaper articles published in the following newspapers: *De Telegraaf, AD/Algemeen Dagblad, de Volkskrant, NRC Handelsblad* and *Trouw*.
4. For the non-accountability treatment, we have opted for a 'pure control' group (i.e. without any information on accountability) rather than a placebo condition that provides participants with outcome-irrelevant information. In the academic literature, there are several concerns about the arbitrariness of placebo conditions that might affect treatment effect estimates (see also Porter and Velez 2022).
5. Trust is often considered as a component of legitimacy, whereby the presence of legitimacy is reflected in explicit manifestations of trust. As Tyler (2006, 2011) has operationalized, legitimacy includes – next to people's willingness to comply with authorities and their decisions – an aspect of trust that these authorities are honest and act in accordance with citizens' interests (see also Tyler and Jackson 2014). Nevertheless, the relationship between legitimacy and trust has spurred debates, and others argue that trust and legitimacy are distinct concepts (Kaina 2008). In this article, we follow the body of literature that considers trust as an 'expression' of perceived legitimacy (Grimes 2006, 2008) and that operationalizes legitimacy beliefs by including citizens' trust in authorities.
6. As a robustness check of our findings, we present the outcomes of a ordered probit regression model in Appendix XI. The interpretation of the relationships, as well as the levels of significance, did not change, with the exception of the interaction effect between loser status and social accountability in Model 3. This effect is not significant anymore at $p < 0.05$, but only at $p < 0.1$.
7. We have checked all our models on possible risks for multicollinearity and outliers using VIF values and Cook's D (reported in Appendix III). In all our models, Cook's D was generally low (cf. Cohen et al. 2013). For our main analyses, the maximum VIF value was 3.468. In our Supplementary Materials, we report a maximum VIF value of 6.975. However, if VIF ≥ 10, this is often considered as an indication of severe multicollinearity (Alin 2010; Cohen et al. 2013).

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Data availability statement

The data are openly available in the LISS archive at https://www.dataarchive.lissdata.nl/.

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